

are also applied to infected gums and have been used to clean the teeth. In Ayurvedic medicine, decoctions of the bark and heartwood are used for sore throats.

Research Cutch has been shown to lower blood pressure.

Related Species See also babul (*Acacia nilotica*, following entry).

Cautions Do not take for more than 2–3 weeks at a time, or if suffering from kidney inflammation. There are some countries where cutch is subject to legal restrictions.

Self-help Use Diarrhea, p. 307.

Acacia nilotica syn. *A. arabica* (Fabaceae)

Babul

Description Tree growing to 65 ft (20 m) with hard, rust-brown bark and feathery leaves. Small, bright yellow flower heads produce pods up to 6 in (15 cm) long.

Habitat & Cultivation Babul is native to North Africa. Today it is commonly found in Egypt and is cultivated in India.

Part Used Bark.

Constituents Babul contains tannins (12–20%), mucilage, and flavonoids.

History & Folklore In ancient Egypt, the wood of the babul tree was used to make dwellings, wheels, and tool handles. The leaves, flowers, and pods were used to expel worms, heal wounds, alleviate diarrhea, and suppress the coughing up of blood.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Strongly astringent, babul is used to contract and toughen mucous membranes throughout the body in much the same way as witch hazel (*Hamamelis virginiana*, p. 102) or oak bark (*Quercus robur*, p. 260). Babul may be made into a variety of preparations: for instance, a lotion for treating bleeding gums, a gargle for easing the irritation of sore throats, a wash for eczema, an eyewash for conjunctivitis and other eye problems, and a douche for excessive vaginal discharge. It is also taken internally to treat diarrhea.

Research Research published in 1993 concluded that babul may be clinically effective in periodontal infections. Another study indicates that the gum stimulates insulin release from the pancreas and lowers blood-sugar levels.

Related Species Australian wattle (*A. decurrens*), native to Australia, is used in much the same way as babul. See also black catechu (*A. catechu*, preceding entry).

Cautions Do not take babul internally for more than 2–3 weeks. *Acacia* species are subject to legal restrictions in some countries.

Acanthus mollis (Acanthaceae)

Acanthus, Bear's Breeches

Description Perennial growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has a black, branched taproot; white, purple, or blue flowers; and dark green basal leaves up to 3 ft (1 m) in length.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, acanthus is most commonly found as a garden plant. It prefers damp sites and low-lying ground. The leaves are gathered in early summer and the roots in autumn.

Parts Used Leaves, roots.

Constituents Acanthus contains large quantities of mucilage and tannin.

History & Folklore Acanthus was well known in the ancient world. Callimachus, a Greek architect of the 5th century BCE, reputedly created the decorative pattern of foliage at the top of Corinthian columns after being inspired by the perfect symmetry of acanthus leaves. The description of acanthus in *Materia Medica*, written in the 1st century CE by the Greek physician



Acanthus flowers blossom on a tall spike.

Dioscorides, is one of the most accurate botanical descriptions to survive from the ancient world. Dioscorides recommended the roots in the form of a plaster to treat burns and to wrap around dislocated joints. As an infusion, acanthus was thought to be diuretic. It was also used to relieve gas and spasms and to soothe damaged nerves.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The herb's appreciable quantities of mucilage and tannin substantiate its traditional use as a treatment for dislocated joints and burns. Its emollient properties make it useful in the treatment of irritated mucous membranes in the digestive and urinary tracts. Acanthus is similar to marshmallow (*Althaea officinalis*, p. 165) in that it can be used externally to ease irritation, and internally to heal and protect.

Achyranthes bidentata (Amaranthaceae)

Chaff flower, Huai Niu Xi (Chinese)

Description Erect perennial herb growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has slender, rambling branches, elliptical leaves, and greenish-white flowers on terminal spikes.

Habitat & Cultivation Chaff flower is found in China at the edge of forests, along streams, and amid bushes. Grown commercially in the eastern provinces, the root is unearthed in winter once the foliage has died back.

Part Used Root.

Constituents *Achyranthes* species contain triterpenoid saponins and sterones.

History & Folklore Chaff flower's potent ability to bring on menstruation led the 13th-century Chinese gynecologist Chen Ziming to prohibit its use during pregnancy to avoid causing miscarriage.

Medicinal Actions & Uses In traditional Chinese medicine, chaff flower is believed to invigorate blood flow. It is used to stimulate menstruation when a period is delayed or scanty. The herb is also prescribed to ease period pain. Chaff flower is used to relieve pain in the lower back, especially where the discomfort is attributable to kidney stones. The herb is also taken as a treatment for canker sores, toothache, bleeding gums, and nosebleeds.

Research Research suggests that chaff flower may lower blood pressure by reducing heart rate and dilating the peripheral arteries.

Related Species *A. aspera*, found in tropical areas worldwide, is used in Ayurvedic medicine to treat chest conditions and a range of digestive problems.

Caution Do not take chaff flower during pregnancy.